

Physicist perceptions on the Intersection of Science and God

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Commentary

Do physicists believe in existence of God? Has modern sciences & technology made faith in God impossible? Does belief in miracles and traditional dogmas require us to deny scientific evidence, or abandon the scientific method? Does religious faith need to fear contemporary science? Try to understand all these puzzles, and let see is there any common intersection exist, i.e., can science and religion coexist together?

In fact, great believing minds have steered the scientific project until today, and still have much to say about the harmony of science and divine faith. There is a widely held belief here that, to borrow the words of late German-born great physicist Albert Einstein “Science without religion was lame; religion without science was blind”, which indicate not only correlation of religion and science, but also indicate neither need nor necessity to prove the existence of supremacy. We believe and teach that God exists and that God is a good and loving creator, but belief is not proof in an empirical or scientific sense. Many prominent scientists in the past have either had a straightforward belief in the God, or else have accepted the existence of some form of supreme supernatural creative intelligence. These scientists include Isaac Newton, James Clerk Maxwell, Charles Darwin, Max Planck, Werner Heisenberg, George Boole, Albert Einstein, etc. Newton, the famous scientist had a belief that there is the presence of God everywhere and we as human’s beings need to acknowledge that and try to explore the Gods creation through the use of science. The great Indian scientist, one of the founding members of ISRO, Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam was also a strong believer of God and used to respect the divine forces too. A survey, presented by the Institute for the Study of Secularism in Society and Culture of Trinity College, Hartford, Connecticut and Hyderabad-based Centre for Inquiry, found that religion and faith had deep roots in the minds of Indian scientists. The book *Cosmos, Bios, Theos* (edited by H. Margenau and R.A. Varghese, Open Court, 1992) is a collection of interviews with 60 prominent scientists, many of them Nobel Prize winners. Thirty-seven of these scientists profess an unambiguous belief in God. On the reverse of that coin, there is no empirical or scientific proof that God does not exist. Great British theoretical physicist Stephen Hawking said “Before we understand science, it is natural to believe that God created the universe. But now science offers a more convincing explanation”. “What I meant by ‘we would know the mind of God’ is, we would know everything that God would know, if there were a God, which there isn’t. When you look at the vast size of the universe, and how insignificant and accidental human life is in it, the existence of a God seems most implausible. I’m an atheist.” In the same way Bertrand Russell, the famous British mathematician and philosopher, did not believe in God. Quantitative data as per Pew Research Centre Report for the religious believe for the general public and scientist can be find in Fig. 1(a).

Religion and science are immiscible like water and oil. They might co-exist, but they can never mix to produce a homogeneous medium. Religion and science are fundamentally incompatible. They disagree profoundly on how we obtain knowledge of the world. Science is based observation and reasoning from observation. Religion assumes that human beings can access a deeper level of information that is not available by either observation or reason. The scientific method is proven by its success. The religious method is refuted by its failure.

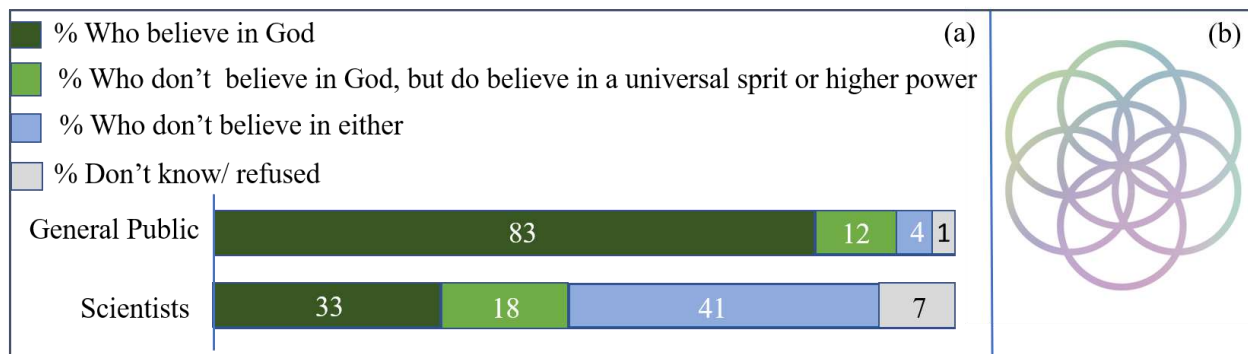


Fig. 1: (a) Religious belief among general public and scientists; (b) Intersection, as per Pew research centre survey report.

Although at first look over the centuries, the relationship between science and religion has ranged from conflict and hostility to harmony and collaboration, while various thinkers have argued that the two concepts are inherently at odds and entirely separate. Apart from the first look, science and religion have more often been complementary to each other, and the relationship has been dynamic. To the best of our understanding there is no any fixed intersection in between. Indeed, lots of intersections are there but which is dynamic in nature See Fig. 1(b).

science and religion may seem quite separate things, it becomes clear that there are numerous connections between the two when they are examined in further detail. Trust is the foundation of religion and science; in the former case, it is confidence in the collected evidence, while in the latter, it is faith in a higher power. Both depend on a set of core beliefs to operate, and throughout human history, both have been used to make sense of the world we live in. Science and religion both rely on faith. In science, faith is required in the existence of an orderly universe that follows laws that can be discovered and understood. In religion, faith is required in the existence of a deity or deities and the teachings of religious texts. Both science and religion require a leap of faith, but they differ in what that faith is based on. For science, faith is based on evidence and reason. The evidence may not be definitive, but it must be strong enough to support the hypothesis. In religion, faith is based on belief. Belief may be based on evidence, but it can also be based on personal experience or intuition (National Academy of Sciences, 2017).

One can call it Ishwar, Allah, God, Waheguru or one can call it dark matter or dark energy still beyond the scope of understanding of human beings. Both God and science are Creator's and both work for the greater good of the society and hence they complement one another instead of competing, and frequently intersecting each other. Indeed, where science and religion differ as science requires proof, religious belief requires faith. Scientists don't try to prove or disprove God's existence because they know there isn't an experiment that can ever detect God. And if you believe in God, it doesn't matter what scientists discover about the Universe – any cosmos can be thought of as being consistent with God. Our views of God, physics or anything else ultimately depends on perspective. But let's end with Terry Pratchett's quote:

"Light thinks it travels faster than anything but it is wrong. No matter how fast light travels, it finds the darkness has always got there first, and is waiting for it.